1099 MONEY · FREE PRINTABLE

The Freelancer Tax Checklist

Everything a US freelancer does about taxes, in the order you do it: once, every payment, every month, every quarter, at year-end and at tax time. Tick it off and April gets boring.

Set up once · Every payment · Monthly · Quarterly, with 2027 dates · Year-end · Tax-time documents



Edition 2027.1 · 2026 and 2027 federal figures

Educational content. Not tax advice.

PART 1

Set up once

An evening's work. Each item makes every later step faster.

MONEY Accounts

- [ ] Open a separate checking account for the business
  Every client payment in, every business cost out.
- [ ] Open a savings account just for tax
  Name it "Taxes". FDIC-insured, ideally earning interest.
- [ ] Choose your set-aside percentage
  Use the table below, add your state's rate, round up.
- [ ] Create an IRS Online Account at irs.gov
  See every payment you've made and pay in a few clicks.

PAPERWORK Identity

- [ ] Decide whether to get an EIN
  Free from irs.gov. Lets you give clients a number other than your SSN on W-9s.
- [ ] Fill in a W-9 once and save it as a PDF
  Clients ask for it before the first payment.
- [ ] Check your state's estimated-tax and business-registration rules

RECORDS Logs

- [ ] An income log: date, client, invoice number, amount
- [ ] An expense log by category, with a receipts folder
  A phone photo the day you get it is enough.
- [ ] A mileage log, if you drive for work
  Date, start and end, miles, purpose. 72.5¢ a mile for 2026.
- [ ] Measure your home office, if you have one
  Exclusive, regular use. Simplified method: $5 a sq ft, up to 300 sq ft.

BENEFITS No employer

- [ ] Choose a retirement account (SEP IRA, Solo 401(k) or IRA)
- [ ] Sort out health insurance
  Marketplace, a spouse's plan, or other coverage. Marketplace open enrollment for 2027 ends Jan 15, 2027.
- [ ] Put the dates on page 4 in your calendar, with a reminder a week before each

Set-aside percentage, federal only

Yearly profit (single, no other income)	$40,000	$60,000	$80,000	$100,000
Federal tax (self-employment + income tax)	≈ $7,430	≈ $12,040	≈ $16,650	≈ $22,360
Set aside from every payment	**19%**	**20%**	**21%**	**22%**

2026 federal figures: 15.3% self-employment tax on 92.35% of profit, the standard deduction ($16,100 single) and the 20% qualified business income deduction. Married filing jointly or other income changes these. Add your state.

PART 2

Every payment, every month

Two small habits. Together they're most of what keeps tax time calm.

EVERY PAYMENT When a client pays you

- [ ] Log it: date, client, invoice number, amount
- [ ] Move your set-aside percentage to the tax account, the same day
- [ ] Note how they paid (bank, card, PayPal and so on)
  Card and payment-app payments may come back on a 1099-K instead of a 1099-NEC.
- [ ] Mark the invoice paid

EVERY MONTH The 30-minute close, on the 1st

- [ ] Categorize last month's business transactions
- [ ] List unpaid invoices and send reminders
- [ ] Add up miles driven for work
- [ ] Total your profit for the year so far
- [ ] Check the tax account: profit so far × set-aside % − estimated payments already made
  Example: $30,000 × 20% − $3,000 paid = $3,000 should be in the account. Top it up if it's short.
- [ ] Write down revenue, profit and the tax-account balance, to compare next month

> **Why profit, not deposits?** Tax is on what's left after business costs. Setting aside on profit, not every deposit, keeps the amount right without overpaying.

WHEN YOU PAY OTHERS Contractors

- [ ] Get a W-9 before the first payment
- [ ] Pay against an invoice, from the business account
- [ ] Track the year's total per contractor
  Paid $2,000 or more in 2026 by bank, check or Zelle? You owe them a 1099-NEC by Feb 1, 2027. Card and PayPal goods-and-services payments are reported by the payment company instead.

PART 3

Every quarter

If you expect to owe $1,000 or more for the year, the IRS expects estimated payments. The periods aren't equal quarters.

Due	Payment	Covers income from
Fri Jan 15, 2027	4th payment for 2026 (choose tax year 2026)	Sep 1 – Dec 31, 2026
Thu Apr 15, 2027	1st payment for 2027, on the same day as your 2026 return	Jan 1 – Mar 31, 2027
Tue Jun 15, 2027	2nd payment for 2027	Apr 1 – May 31
Wed Sep 15, 2027	3rd payment for 2027	Jun 1 – Aug 31
Tue Jan 18, 2028*	4th payment for 2027	Sep 1 – Dec 31

*Jan 15, 2028 falls on a Saturday and Jan 17 is a federal holiday. Confirm on irs.gov when the 2027 Form 1040-ES is out. Your state may have different dates.

A WEEK BEFORE The 15-minute routine

- [ ] Catch up the income and expense logs
- [ ] Pick the amount: the *smaller* of
  - a quarter of last year's total tax (110% of it if last year's AGI was over $150,000), or
  - 90% of this year's projected tax, spread across the year. Paying it on time generally avoids the underpayment penalty.
- [ ] Pay at irs.gov/payments: Direct Pay or your Online Account → estimated tax → Form 1040-ES
  Choose the right **tax year**. Using EFTPS? Schedule it at least a day ahead.
- [ ] Save the confirmation number with the date and amount
- [ ] Pay your state's estimate too, if it has one

Missed one? Pay as soon as you can. The underpayment penalty works like interest, so it grows with time; paying now stops it growing on that amount.

PART 4

Year-end and tax time

DECEMBER Before Dec 31

- [ ] Project this year's profit and compare it with what you've set aside
- [ ] Plan the Jan 15 payment (or plan to file and pay in full by Feb 1)
- [ ] Buy equipment only if the business needs it
  It must be in service by Dec 31 to count this year. A $1,000 cost saves roughly $230 at $60,000 of profit, not $1,000.
- [ ] Chase unpaid invoices
  Most freelancers are taxed when paid, not when they invoice.
- [ ] Total the year's miles and note the Dec 31 odometer
- [ ] Collect W-9s from anyone you'll owe a 1099-NEC

DEADLINES Retirement and health

- [ ] IRA and HSA for 2026: by Apr 15, 2027
- [ ] SEP IRA for 2026: by your filing deadline, including an extension (Oct 15, 2027)
- [ ] Solo 401(k): check the plan's setup and contribution deadlines with the provider

JAN – APR Gather for the return

- [ ] Every 1099 you receive (NEC, K, INT, MISC)
  Arrive by Feb 1, 2027. Report all income, even without a form.
- [ ] Your own income total from the log
  It won't match the 1099s exactly. Use your records.
- [ ] Expense totals by Schedule C category
- [ ] Business miles, and home office square footage
- [ ] Health insurance premiums (Form 1095-A if marketplace)
- [ ] Retirement and HSA contributions
- [ ] Every 2026 estimated payment, with dates (your IRS Online Account lists them)
- [ ] Last year's return

BY APR 15 File

- [ ] File, or extend (an extension is more time to file, not to pay)
- [ ] Pay any 2026 balance
- [ ] Make the 1st 2027 estimated payment, same day
- [ ] Keep the return and records for at least 3 years

Free tools that do the math: the quarterly tax calculator, the January 15 calculator, the deduction finder and the rate calculator, all at **1099money.netlify.app**. Nothing you type is sent anywhere.

Educational content, not tax, legal or financial advice. Figures are 2026 federal (IRS Rev. Proc. 2025-32, SSA wage base) for a calendar-year sole proprietor; dates checked against IRS rules as of November 2026. Confirm on irs.gov and with your state before acting.